

Our New World

I think we should keep it as small and simple as we can. By this I mean that we should concentrate only on the immediate region or country in which Eastwitch and The Capital are located, at the most. There is no need to establish 30 different kingdoms, or continents.

I would rather run two assumptions:

1. That the average human never travels more than 10 or 20 miles from his home during his entire lifetime, thus making knowledge of “foreign parts” extremely limited. (This also gives free reign to others who would DM in the future to develop their corners of the world however they see fit.)
2. That the world is a very dangerous place, overpopulated by monsters, evil humanoids, and other great perils, thus limiting the scope and extent of true exploration of the continent. So the “known world” as perceived by a citizen of Eastwitch consists of solely their town, the few surrounding villages and towns within easy or safe riding distance, and The Capital. A citizen of The Capital might perceive the “known world” to be slightly bigger, with some greater knowledge of a few, but not many, of the outside kingdoms and regions.

Let us start with a brief outline. Eventually, each topic should deserve its own separate Word document, but for now, to get things started, just an outline of all the areas we need to cover and address. I’m sure more will crop up as we get going, but for now, this is what I can come up with.

Write in your comments/changes/etc right in this document with a different colour font if you like.

1. Geography

I’m going to leave this entirely up to you. Mostly, the geography and geographical aspects of the world require map building and a fair bit of drawing. Your skills in this area are far, far superior to mine. We all enjoy a Blacky Map thoroughly, and I think this topic should be yours, and yours alone.

2. Physics

This should only really be taken care of briefly, but it is something that we need to address. Do the physical laws of the world operate in the same manner as they do here in the real world? I imagine the answer is “conditionally yes”, with the condition being that since it is a magical world, these physical laws can be sufficiently bent to allow for magical effects to occur. However, we need to draw the line somewhere. The easiest answer is to draw the line in the same place that standard D&D does, allowing for a certain degree of suspension of disbelief and realism. However, if we

are creating a more realistic world, we need to tinker with the physics. I'd discourage tinkering too much, or going too realistic, simply because then we have to go through each and every spell, each and every magical item, each and every magical power, etc to determine how it is affected by a change in the natural laws and physics of the place.

Conversely, allowing too much latitude in this area results in an overly unrealistic game experience, where physics, and the physical laws of the place are meaningless.

Standard D&D physics is the easy answer, but we can work it out to whatever we want.

3. Cosmology

If we are going to have a world where deities (whether Angels/Saints and Devils/Daemons) grant spells to clerics, some sort of Cosmology needs to be created. A Cosmology is also necessary for dealing with creatures of the Outsider, Elemental, Ethereal, etc classifications. A great deal of magic and monsters depend on alternate planes of existence and the Great Wheel of the Cosmos.

However, there is nothing tying us down to the great multitude of planes that both the Forgotten Realms and the standard D&D rules use (in fact I think the Forgotten Realms Cosmology is even more complicated than the standard DMG one.) I actually suggest a simpler structure with the following Cosmology:

1. *The Inner Planes:* all the Inner Planes, and their structures remain the same. There is little reason to change these as they form an integral part of many spells and spell effects, as well as quite a few monsters.

- Astral Plane
- Material Plane
- Plane of Shadow
- Ethereal Plane
- Positive Energy Plane
- Negative Energy Plane
- Elemental Plane of Fire
- Elemental Plane of Water
- Elemental Plane of Air
- Elemental Plane of Earth

2. *The Outer Planes:* I think there need be only three outer planes. Especially when we are talking about a monotheistic world. All the multitude of outer planes tends to complicate things, especially when we are going to have a campaign wherein planar travel does not feature. Most of the outer planes can probably be relegated to being sub-domains or realms within the main outer planes. The outer planes that we should keep, in my opinion are these:

- Celestia (or Heaven)
- Baator (or Hell)
- The Abyss

My reasoning for this is thus: Celestia is where all the Angels/Saints will dwell. Most of the Good-aligned and Neutral-aligned beings can probably reside here in smaller domains and realms. Baator and the Abyss will obviously house the Devils and Daemons, but I think The Blood War is interesting enough to keep the two separate from each other. Besides, Good knows how to compromise and live in harmony (hence the overall unity of Celestia for beings of any of the Good and Neutral alignments.) Evil knows no compromise, so there is no way for any reconciliation or cooperation between the eternal enemies of Hell and the Abyss.

As far as Neutrality goes, they can be assigned to either Celestia or Hell or the Abyss, depending on how each creature tends (Pandemonium, and its creatures, can probably be assigned to an upper level of The Abyss, and Arcadia and its creatures to a lower level of the Celestia, and so on.)

Alternatively, all neutral beings (whether deities, creatures, etc) can be assigned to drift in the eternal purgatory of the Astral Plane.

Of course, the full range of planes can also be considered. In simplifying the Cosmology, I am probably making it more complex to manage. So, the easiest option is to default to the Cosmology presented in the DMG. The work for us then is to reconcile our monotheistic religion with that Cosmology. But more on that topic in the Religion section.

4. Magic

Well, magic is a big deal, obviously. And a big topic. The first thing to deal with is the nature of the thing. In the Forgotten Realms, they've got the whole Mystra and the Weave thing. In the standard D&D setting, I don't think there is an explanation. A reasonable, and somewhat rational explanation of magic needs to be put in place. Maybe "Magic" is just a 5th Element of sorts? Maybe it is the glue that holds the whole Cosmology together? I defer to you on this topic. What we should not have is the sort of "magic just is" approach.

We also should consider where magic comes from, and what types of magic there are in the world. For example, I had suggested three different types of magic:

1. Arcane (or New Magic)
2. Druidic (or Old Magic)
3. Divine

Arcane magic is that practiced by wizards, sorcerors and bards, as well as quite a few prestige classes. It is also behind the vast majority of magic items, constructs and effects. I refer to it as “New” magic, simply because I think arcane magic should rely on some degree of civilisation. In the history of our new world, arcane magic was not possible without civilisation. Pre-Historic tribes and peoples used magic to some degree, but the magic they used was Druidic, or Old Magic. With civilisation came education and knowledge. And with education and knowledge came the ability to shape magic energy in whatever way humanity saw fit. The end result of this is arcane magic, which allows for item creation, for researched spells, and so on.

Druidic magic comes from the soil, and should be the oldest magic in the world. It is the magic of the world itself, and no one should be able to understand it thoroughly. Its age and complexity should make it confusing to all who witness it, even to most of its practitioners. Druids should not worship any god at all.

Divine magic is a bit more confusing. In D&D it presupposes that a Deity gets directly involved in the affairs of the world by personally granting its priests spells. Since we are modifying the religion of our world, divine magic needs the greatest work to explain and to reconcile.

Which brings us to...

5. Religion

This is a big topic. It is true what the DMG says, and what history has shown us: there is no greater force for change in all the world than religion. How we style the religion(s) of our world will ultimately determine almost every single aspect of the world as a whole.

I think this is perhaps our greatest challenge, as well as our biggest opportunity to set this world apart from every other D&D world out there.

I’m only leaving this here simply because it is such a large and complex topic that if I get into it now, I won’t get to any of the rest. We’ll talk about religion separately later.

6. Mythology

Every good world needs a mythology. If for no other reason than for flavour. Mythology sets the world apart as unique. However, there are a few standard myths that every world ought to have.

1. *The Creation Myth:* every world, or society, has an idea of how the world was created. The typical Ancient myth is that of the male Sky-father and the female Earth-mother coming to be from the chaos of the cosmos. The Sky-father then impregnates the Earth-mother and away we go. In a monotheistic world, we need to decide if the same God has been the one true God the whole time, or if it is a God that has supplanted some previous Gods.

Or, perhaps it was a God from a pantheon that either slew or dominated its rivals to assume overall control of existence. Still, a good creation myth is needed, and it will provide the backbone for not only any subsequent myths, but also for the entire religious system.

2. *The Saviour Myth:* every good world has a good saviour myth. This is the Myth of the Chosen One who will rise up against the evils and injustices of the world and lead us all into an eternal heaven on Earth. Whether he is called Moses, or Jesus, or Mohammed, or King Arthur, or Anakin Skywalker, or Neo, or Aragorn or whatever, every society, especially societies who live in darkness, fear, repression, oppression, or simply under brutal conditions, need a myth of a saviour. Usually this is even more powerful and more important than the myth of creation.

There are a few other myths that need to be thrown in as well. The creation of the Nine Hells and The Abyss is almost certainly necessary. There needs to be an explanation for the existence of Evil. Supposing of course, that Good is the ideal. A creation of the species myth is also good, though not as necessary. It could just as well see evolution as mythology as an Adam & Eve type story. And then there are all the other minor stories of morality that are meant to teach the people lessons on life, as well as just plain stories like the quest for the Holy Grail, Robin Hood, Hercules, Jason and the Argonauts, and so on that enter into the collective mythology and are known and referenced by all.

I think these are important for flavour. They are also more important in a world where magical items are each a unique creation. When you've got Saint Lazarus' Lance in your hands, it helps for the DM to know who Saint Lazarus was, and why his magical Lance was important. After all, we have magic items in the real world: from Excalibur, to the Holy Grail, to Thor's Hammer, to Moses' Staff, to the Arc of the Covenant, and so on. We know the stories behind all those as myths. Our PC's are going to be dealing with more minor items rather than something like Excalibur, but it helps to have some big myths regarding some rather impressive and important people and items from the distant past that provide impetus and motivation, and not just flavour.

7. Demographics

The demographics of our world come in two flavours: historic and current. Basically, who populated our world in the past, and who populates it now? Traditionally, the elves, dwarves and orcs did in the past, and humans and orcs do so in the present. but our world can take whatever shape and history we want it to.

First, though, we should agree on what major races (that is, the races that will be available to player characters) are going to be present, as well as what minor races, that can provide DM-approved PC's as well as some of the nastier NPCs.

I suggest the following:

1. *Humans*: our standard stock. I don't think humans should be the dominant race in our world. Disease, monsters, orc wars, and so on should have limited the spread and reach of humanity to some degree. One of the main aspects I would like to see, as I said in my initial email, is to have a world where just leaving the line of sight to the buildings of your village is considered somewhat dangerous. I'm thinking a lot about Wolfson, and how that type of atmosphere of fear of the wild (though maybe not to that extent) should be present here. Certainly humanity isn't the most widely spread of all the races. Perhaps it has strongholds in a small area (about the size of New England and the Maritimes, say) made up of about a dozen kingdoms and nations. These kingdoms are small, and mostly self-sufficient, and perhaps deeply suspicious of one another. Within and without, monsters inhabit and threaten their existence. Just an idea. Overall, though, I'm thinking that maybe no more than about 10 million humans populate the world. 10 million is still considerable, but certainly not dominant.
2. *Elves & Half-Elves*: I gave you my thoughts on what I think elves and half-elves would be like. Confined to an extremely small population, nearing extinction. Half-elves should be a little more plentiful, but not by much. I'm thinking there should be no more than about 50,000 elves left alive on the planet, most of them fairly elderly. Half-elves, maybe 100,000-200,000. I don't think there needs to be any subrace of elves, save for the drow. Furthermore, I'd rather not call them "elves". I think we should come up with a new name for all the different non-human races.
3. *Orcs & Half-Orcs*: I think these bad boys should be the dominant humanoid population on the planet. They should even be organised into some loose kingdoms or empires in some places. However, it is their distinct lack of organisation and internecine fighting that keeps them from overrunning the rest of the "civilised" races. Orcs should number in the tens of millions, with half-orcs numbering just a couple million. I think PC's should have the option of playing a full-blooded Orc. They'd have a damn hard time in human lands, though.
4. *Halflings & Gnomes*: I'm torn on these guys. I can see the point of having them around, but to me they just make little sense. They were just included in the game because people wanted the opportunity to play hobbits. But in D&D 3.5 they're not hobbits at all. I'd almost be tempted to get rid of Halflings along with Gnomes. Or, maybe relegate them to some very minor role. I'd rather consolidate the roles typically played by Gnomes and Halflings and introduce a subrace of Goblin to take their place. A signature feature of our world could be the inclusion of a

customised and civilised goblin subrace for PC and NPC use.

5. *Dwarves*: I like your idea of Dwarves. Not much more to say on that. I think they should be xenophobic, clannish, stubborn, and have a damn good reason to be out on the surface.
6. *Planetouched*: since one of the underlying features of this new world will likely be the religious battle between Good & Evil (Saints & Devils, Angels & Demons) I see no reason to restrict Assimars and Tieflings from being a part of this world. However, most of our concern should be local, not global in scope, so these guys should only come into play in passing. That is, with DM permission in order to support a good character concept, or as NPC villains. I'm not so sure a place can be found for the Genasi in our world. In the email-only Wastrel campaign I was doing this time last year (before it had to be abandoned, sadly) my main bad guys were a team of four Genasi (each of a different element.) I still think Genasi make damn fine NPC villains, but I'm not so sure they are appropriate for PC races.
7. *Drow*: along with the Orcs, Drow should be fairly dominant in our world. Although, only if an Underdark is present. If there is no Underdark concept (and that would rob us of many worthy enemies) I still think the Drow should be around in one form or another, but just not dominant. Dark elves make great adversaries, as we have found out in Waterdeep. However, they should not be player characters.

So, basically, as I see it, you've got a continent where the vast majority of the territory is wild and uncharted. In this terra incognita, monsters proliferate almost unchecked. The most dominant humanoid species, found in this uncharted land, are the orcs, though their lack of organisation and constant warfare keeps their numbers somewhat in check. They are also fairly spread out within this vast territory.

Humans are the second most populous humanoid race, and they have achieved a high level of civilisation and technological achievement. However, these achievements, even when coupled with magic, have not been enough to grant safety from the threats of the world beyond their immediate borders, so humanity remains clustered in a small, mostly coastal region where they have formed a handful of kingdoms and city-states. The bravest (or most foolish) of humans live on the fringes of these states, under constant threat from the perils of the wild beyond.

Elves, the earliest humanoid race to evolve on the world, is all but extinct. Warfare against the orcs and drow, as well as disease, coupled with their long generational gaps, have led to their demise. Only a small community remains in the last Elven city. The war is over, and the dark elves won.

Little is actually known of the dwarves. Paranoid and suspicious, the little bastards rarely come out from their mountain homes.

Goblins are a necessary nuisance. Both slaves and free-men (beasts?) Goblins inhabit the world in parallel within Human and Orcish communities. In Orcish lands, goblins are wild, ferocious little beasts, often tamed as slaves by the Orcs and larger humanoids. In human lands, goblins have been tamed for several centuries, and used as slaves and in professions where manpower is needed, but humans would rather not do the work themselves. Over the generations, many goblins have won their freedom, and some have even become somewhat educated.

Here and there, there are rumours of planetouched individuals. Patriarchs of the faiths, torturers, leaders of crusades, tyrant overlords... some are said to be Angels and Devils themselves, or, at least, descended from them.

8. History

This one is another of those fairly open-ended topics, that can somewhat be left for future DM's to fill in some of the blanks. However, a basic structure and some more or less major events need to be set down. Ancient and fallen civilisations, history of the development of the organised religions, etc.

Since the point at the start is to keep things local, some history of the town and country we're playing in needs to be set down. This means Eastwitch, which means this is yours.

9. Politics

Same goes for politics. Leave it be for the DM's, and Eastwitch is yours. Some greater political thoughts need to be included. Like who rules the kingdom.

I'd like to see Eastwitch be an old frontier town (that is, not a colony, but rather a town that has marked the border of its country with the wild for several centuries.) The country itself that Eastwitch is loosely a part of, I'd like to see be some form of very old, hereditary absolute monarchy. In fact, I'd like to see it be just a city-state (The Capital, plus outlying towns and farms) ruled by an Arch-Duke (or something) in an absolute monarchy sort of way. Benevolent tyranny, though sometimes straying towards the not so benevolent and cruel. But that's just me. I don't want towns run by adventurers, or merchant cabals. I want to see an old, established noble family with absolute grip on power over the city-state. However, once you get out from beneath the shadows of the city walls, despite being nominally within the Capital's political control, each town pretty much runs itself.

10. Technology

I've been thinking a lot about this, and the more I think about it, the more I like the idea of 1750-1800 as a technological/developmental benchmark for our world. Since I see magic as being a bit more rare and more subtle than in typical D&D worlds, I can see technology playing an increased part. Firearms, for example, should be included, and maybe even provide the main weaponry. For example, I see a typical

frontier townsman carrying a musket as a primary weapon, and a hand-axe or knife as a secondary weapon. Trained soldiers would probably use a sword (though rapiers and sabres being much more common, and longswords and shortwords relegated to antique relics and family heirlooms) as their secondary weapon. Bows would be common, especially on the frontiers, where missile weapons are needed, but gunpowder and bullets are rare and expensive to get. Crossbows a little more expensive, but probably just as common as the skill required to use one is not as great as that needed to use a bow.

I like the suggestion of 1750. But I want firearms to play an equivalent role. Basically, between firearms and magic, armour is pretty much practically obsolete within human civilised lands.

The firearms stats in the DMG aren't as crazy as the old AD&D 2ed arquebus rules, so I don't see why we don't give them a try. It has been a long time since I fired a gun at the gaming table.

Other bits of technology we should assess on a case-by-case basis. I mean, in a world with magic, and where humanity is not the dominant life-form, we really have to assess the need for certain technological innovations. The steam-engine? Mass-production? etc.

The same goes for medical advances, farming techniques, scientific principles, etc.

Firearms don't bend the imagination too much, since gunpowder is an easy chemical composition to discover and utilise (as the Chinese did for a millennia before the Europeans got their hands on it.) And low-yield firearms not too much of a stretch to envision and produce, even if there is magic, and humanity is not overly abundant. Bows and arrows, and crossbows might still be cheaper to produce and more effective, but the benefits of firearms are still apparent: little to no skill is required to use them, and reloading can be done quite quickly. When compared with a bow and arrow, which can be reloaded quickest of all, but which requires some serious skill to use; or with a crossbow, which requires little skill to use but takes a long time to reload; firearms make sense as weapons, if you can afford them. If we are playing in the approximate year 1750-1800, I would classify firearms as part of the list of Simple Weapon Proficiencies, and not Exotic Weapon Proficiencies, as they would be in the Middle Ages.

11. Economics

This is a topic as big as Religion. However, this is perhaps one of the very last things we need to put in place. Whether or not our world works properly will be shown to us when we put the economy in motion, and I suspect we will be tinkering with this one constantly.

The Arms & Equipment Guide has a couple of good tables related to trade and economic systems. Though not extensive, the three or four tables can be handy as a template for dealing with the wealth to population ratio of settlements.

I think, despite what the DMG says, we should keep our economy based on silver, rather than on gold. In a way, this will screw up some perceptions for the PC's. Think of Todd or Scun or me or any of the other guys, who've always known prices in D&D as being in GP. So a longsword is 10gp, say. Now, come back to them and say a longsword in Eastwicht costs £1,200, they'll go apeshit. They won't know what is worth what. At least not at first. Is £1,200 too much, or too little? Obviously the characters will know what something is worth, but the players won't. It is a little bit of cheating on our part, but this keeps their wealth gains in check. It also keeps their expectations in check. And it allows a bit of leniency to adjust the economic system on the fly.

I think we should stick to a silver coin (and maybe even paper money), where denominations are measured by the weight of the silver content within each coin. This would also mean that when PC's find treasure of ancient gold coins, for example, they have to exchange it for modern currency, not at face value, but rather by weight of the purity of the gold in each coin. They may be expecting the standard D&D exchange rate of 1gp=10sp, but, in our world, 1gp when measured by weight of the gold content, could be only 3sp. Then again, the value of the coins as antique collectibles could mean that the exchange results in the PC getting an exchange rate of 1gp=40sp or something like that.

It means keeping track of individual coins, and with players who are half-assed book-keepers sometimes, it may prove difficult. I can trust Robertson to systematically record everything down, but Todd and his character sheet? But if we do it right, it should actually come out fine.

12. Monster Ecology

This is basically going through the Monster Manuals, monster by monster, and deciding if that monster is present in our world. If it is, it means writing out an ecology for it. Give it a habitat and a geographical range, and logically explain why this creature would survive where it does. Magical aberrations and mutations explain away most monsters, but they have to have a solid reason for surviving where they do.

We're not doing a world where a band of Hobgoblins can survive in a sealed and trapped room of the 7th level of a dungeon for centuries without food or water until a group of adventurers stumbles upon them.

I actually liked the Warhammer RPG reliance on mutations and corruptions. I think that is a theme we should steal and run with it for our monsters.

Furthermore, if you've got time on your hands for some reason, let's try to make some monsters unique to our world. That way, instead of tossing out another displacer beast or gnoll that the players know all about from reading the Monster Manual, let's try and come up with some unique monsters they've never heard of or seen before.

Okay. This is it for now. I've been typing for a few hours, and it's my turn to change my daughter's diaper, and then I have to go cook dinner. There's more areas we need to discuss and add to the outline, but this can get us started.